

remember getting my first cavity filled. Back then, dentists' offices weren't adorned with coloring books, aquariums, and TV screens to distract terrified children. They were designed, in fact, specifically to terrify children. Dentists wore masks over their mouths and offered no reassurances that the needle wouldn't hurt. Heck, they didn't even try to hide the giant syringe! My mother was no help, sitting there with tears in her eyes as she watched the point sink into my gums. I'm not sure what hurt more—watching my mother cringe or the needle itself. Either way, this is how I learned cavities were a very, very bad thing. I never wanted another one.

After the nightmare was over, my mother and the dentist sat me down for a chat (it was a one-way conversation because my mouth was still numb). They explained that brushing my teeth more often meant I'd get fewer cavities. Fewer cavities meant fewer visits to this nightmarish place, the source of some real childhood trauma. Because of that pain and terror, I slowly began to understand that there was a connection, a tangible one, between disciplined behavior and rewards, even if the rewards really just took the form of pain avoidance. I decided to brush my teeth regularly, and eventually even learned to enjoy it.

Too bad we can't give teenagers one small financial cavity to teach them a lesson about spending and saving and the importance of building good financial habits. Teens are notoriously undisciplined (as I said before, I know because I have a couple). But teenagers are highly attuned to rewards. Consider compound-interest charts. They're numerical rewards for disciplined behavior. The dental equivalent would be a picture of a healthy smile unmarred by cavities, unthreatened by needles. As with brushing your teeth, compound-interest charts show you what's possible with disciplined behavior over time, time being the one big thing, if not the only thing, teenagers have going for them as investors.

Let's keep the numbers simple. Let's say you're not quite ready to set aside your Secret 10 yet. But you can set aside \$2,000, a chunk of cash you earned over the course of the summer you turned 17 by babysitting for the family down the street. Let's look at what that \$2,000 would be worth at retirement age, *if you never put in another*